

The house that the Butcher built

Synopsis: Ta Mok's former lakeside mansion in Takeo, once a bastion of Khmer Rouge power, stands forgotten, highlighting the urgent need to preserve it as a witness to Cambodia's darkest era.

Men Kiri

A gentle stroll across a short bridge brings you to the former lakeside home of Takeo province's most notorious son, Ta Mok—the Khmer Rouge commander of the Southwestern Zone who oversaw the horrific atrocities of the regime.

Born Chhit Choeun in 1925, Ta Mok was one of the most powerful and feared leaders of the Khmer Rouge and a central figure in Cambodia's darkest period. Known as "The Butcher," he earned the nickname for his brutality, especially during his leadership of the Southwestern Zone, where mass executions, and forced evacuations were carried out with extreme violence.

Ta Mok oversaw systematic purges, mass killings, forced labour, and internal executions. The zone he commanded was notorious even by Khmer Rouge standards for the severity of the repression. He was instrumental in sending thousands of "enemies" to S-21 (Tuol Sleng), where they were tortured and killed.

In the late 1990s, after the collapse of the genocidal Democratic Kampuchea, Ta Mok became Pol Pot's fiercest rival within the collapsing Khmer Rouge. In 1997, Ta Mok's faction overthrew Pol Pot and placed him under house arrest shortly before his death in 1998.

Still, there was no happy ending for the Butcher. After decades evading justice, he was captured by Cambodian government forces in 1999 near the Thai border. Charged with genocide and crimes against humanity, he died in 2006 in military detention before ever facing trial.

History buffs and travellers are often more familiar with Ta Mok's other residence near Anlong Veng, the last stronghold of Khmer Rouge. However, it was actually his Takeo mansion which bore witness to numerous significant events that made Ta Mok the symbol of atrocities from 1975-1979).

According to verified documents from Case 002 from Extraordinary Chambers in the Courts of Cambodia, it was this mansion where Ta Mok informed military commanders that



The former lakeside home of Takeo province's most notorious son. Men Kiri



Chhit Choeun, known as the Butcher because of his brutality as one of the most powerful and feared leaders of the Khmer Rouge. DC-CAM



The maze-like interior of the house that the Butcher designed himself. Men Kiri

the Standing Committee had made the decision to purge the East Zone, and subsequently spoke of preparing forces. Subsequently, he sent Southwest Zone forces to the East Zone to counter Vietnamese forces and "cleanse" those who collaborated with the Vietnamese.

Seum Srim, a former Khmer Rouge child soldier who was assigned to simple tasks, such as mowing the lawn, remembers seeing Ta Mok arrive at the mansion in his four-wheel drive, accompanied by two young bodyguards, to have a meeting with other senior cadres of the Khmer Rouge.

"He never talked to me, but the way he spoke made me believe that he was an extremely serious guy," Srim, 60, said. "However, to me, he was not scary. To many of his subordinates, he was a nice man, usually granting their requests."

The mansion's architecture and location also made it stand out when Ta Mok was at the peak of his power.

"It was built during the Khmer Rouge regime at the centre of the lake and could only be reached through a narrow wooden bridge," Srim said. "On the top open floor of the house stood soldiers with machine guns, always ready to attack anyone entering the house without permission."

Ta Mok himself designed the house and picked the building materials, Srim added.

"Each brick was as hard as stone, making the mansion more like a fortress," he said. "Inside the house, there were rooms and spiral staircases. Finding your way inside was a puzzle, and people who did not know the way got lost easily."

"No one knew which room Ta Mok slept in."

However, over the years, the mansion's infamy faded, as the building fell under the control of the government and was used as a training centre for the provincial police force. In the 2010s, it served as the provincial

branch of a private university, resulting in heavy renovations that destroyed most of the original design.

During the COVID-19 outbreak, the university moved out. Ta Mok's mansion now stands abandoned, like its original owner in the last period of his life.

Despite its significant history, the building is now reduced to a place where teenagers and young people hang out. Sexually-explicit scribbles and drawings now dominate the walls and staircases. Broken glasses, peeling paints, empty cans and food waste are the only things now found in its rooms.

Seum Srim, who is personally connected to building, can only express regret that the home of his former boss has not been well-preserved. Having settled in a far smaller house nearby, all he could do now is tell visitors its past story.

"I want it to be a historical museum which stores memorabilia

and collectibles from the Khmer Rouge regime to attract tourists and at the same time teach our young generations about the history," he said.

The suggestion was also made by Pheng Pong Rasy, Director of the Genocide Education Program in Cambodia and Director of the Prey Veng and Takeo Documentation Centers.

"It is crucial to preserve Ta Mok's former house because it is one of the few surviving physical sites directly tied to key decisions, events, and personalities of the Khmer Rouge regime—making it an irreplaceable historical record of Cambodia's darkest period," he said.

"As Cambodia modernises, many Khmer Rouge-era structures are disappearing. Preserving this house would allow future generations to confront the realities of the regime, strengthening national memory and preventing historical distortion." ■